

Work and home

Traditionally, it was the man of the house who was the “breadwinner”—earning money for all the family—and in many cultures, women have been expected to stay at home and do “women’s work,” such as cooking, cleaning, and bringing up children. But today, especially in richer developed countries, most women go out to work, and more are taking on jobs that were previously considered “men’s work.” Economists are recognizing that women who do housework do actually have a job, but that it’s unpaid work. Now that many women are going out to work, couples often share the housework, or may pay for someone else to do it.

One way of balancing the demands of home and work is to take a part-time job. Although this was an option for mothers, so that they had time for looking after children, it’s becoming more common for men, too. Some employers even allow “job-sharing,” where one job is divided between two or more people. Working fewer hours per day, or fewer days per week, gives more time for family or other interests, but of course, means less income, and may not be possible for everyone.